

one port, any tool

MCP Starter Guide

Reel dekh ke aaye ho? Ye wahi starter guide hai. MCP kya hai, API se kaise alag hai, aur 10 minute mein pehla MCP server kaise chalte ho. No fluff.

THE ONE-LINE DIFFERENCE

API

written for developers

One door into one product. A developer decides what to call, when, and with which parameters.

MCP

written for the model

A standard plug. The tool describes itself once; the model discovers it and decides what to call.

MCP does not replace APIs. Every MCP server still calls an API underneath.

Anthropic's own docs put it in one sentence: *"Think of MCP like a USB-C port for AI applications."*

API VS MCP

	API	MCP
Who calls it	Your code	The AI model, at runtime
Discovery	Read the docs, write the integration	Server lists its tools; the model reads them
10 tools × 5 AI apps	50 custom integrations	15 connections through one protocol
Where it runs	Wherever you deploy it	Locally (stdio) or remote (HTTP)
Owner	Each vendor	Open standard, Linux Foundation (Agentic AI Foundation) since Dec 2025
Adopted by	Everyone, for decades	Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, Copilot, Cursor, VS Code

HOW IT WORKS

Host Claude Desktop, ChatGPT, Cursor, VS Code	Client Lives inside the host, one per server	MCP server Exposes tools, resources, prompts	Your stuff Files, GitHub, Postgres, Slack, any API
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A server offers three things: **tools** (functions the model can call), **resources** (data it can read), and **prompts** (reusable templates). Most servers you'll use are just tools.

1 Install Node.js

Version 18 or newer from nodejs.org. Most servers run with `npx`, so this is the only prerequisite.

2 Open the config file

macOS: `~/Library/Application`

`Support/Claude/claude_desktop_config.json`

Windows: `%APPDATA%\Claude\claude_desktop_config.json`

Create it if it doesn't exist.

3 Add the filesystem server

Replace the path with a folder you're happy to expose. Only the folders you list are visible.

```
{
  "mcpServers": {
    "filesystem": {
      "command": "npx",
      "args": [
        "-y",
        "@modelcontextprotocol/server-filesystem",
        "C:\\\\Users\\you\\Desktop"
      ]
    }
  }
}
```

4 Restart Claude Desktop

A tools icon appears under the message box. Ask: *"List the files on my Desktop and summarise the newest one."* Claude asks permission before each tool call. That permission prompt is MCP working.

Cursor and VS Code use the same JSON shape: Cursor reads `.cursor/mcp.json` in your project, VS Code reads `.vscode/mcp.json` (key is `servers` instead of `mcpServers`).

SERVICES WORTH INSTALLING FIRST

Filesystem

Read and edit files in allowed folders. The reference server.

Git

Log, diff, commit from chat. Same reference repo.

GitHub

Issues, PRs, code search. Maintained by GitHub.

Playwright

Drive a real browser: open pages, click, fill forms.

Fetch

Pull a web page as clean markdown.

Memory

A small knowledge graph the model can remember across chats.

Notion

Search and edit your workspace. Official Notion server.

The registry

Thousands more, with namespace verification. Search before you build.

BUILD YOUR OWN IN 12 LINES · PYTHON

The official SDK ships FastMCP. A function with a docstring becomes a tool the model can see.

```
pip install "mcp[cli]"
```

```
from mcp.server.fastmcp import FastMCP

mcp = FastMCP("my-tools")

@mcp.tool()
def gst_total(amount: float, rate: float = 18) -> float:
    """Return the amount including GST at the given rate (%)."""
    return round(amount * (1 + rate / 100), 2)

if __name__ == "__main__":
    mcp.run()
```

```
mcp dev server.py      # opens the MCP Inspector to test the tool
mcp install server.py  # registers it in Claude Desktop
```

Type hints become the tool's schema, the docstring becomes its description. That description is the whole reason the model knows when to call it, so write it like you're explaining to a new hire.

BEFORE YOU CONNECT ANYTHING

- ✓ A server runs on your machine with your permissions. Install only ones you'd run as a script.
 - ✓ Least privilege: list only the folders, repos, or databases the job needs.
 - ✓ Read the tool call before approving it. The permission prompt exists for a reason.
 - ✓ Keep API keys in environment variables (the `envfield` in the config), never in prompts.
 - ✓ MCP servers still hit APIs underneath, so rate limits and bills still apply.
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READ NEXT

[modelcontextprotocol.io — official docs and quickstart](#)

[The specification \(2026-07-28 release\)](#)

[Anthropic's launch post, Nov 25 2024](#)

[Linux Foundation: Agentic AI Foundation, Dec 9 2025](#)

[Python SDK](#)

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[TypeScript SDK](#)

From the reel "API vs MCP". Questions? Reply in DM.

Facts checked September 2026. Every claim above links to its source.